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Firodia now practises over the weekends and it is his way of relaxing and rejuvenating. “The sound made by the handpan is extremely soothing. It’s like being in a spa,” he says. He refers to himself as a beginner and says that since not too many people play the instrument in India, finding a teacher is difficult. However, he has now connected with some teachers online and is hoping to start learning properly soon.

“I like creating my own tunes. There are very few people playing the instrument in India, so finding someone to teach me is also difficult. I am learning online.”

Firodia launched You Care Lifestyle last year in October. He plans to launch an app soon. Currently maximum sales come from metro cities but he is slowly getting customers from Tier II cities as well. The platform encourages sale of local produce. Firodia says it’s also about educating consumers about the benefits of organic and chemical-free products. Firodia also has a tech company and runs a platform called ‘I love Nagar’, which is for the city of Ahmednagar, near Pune where he stays. The app enables citizens to raise and address an issue, contributing to the development of the city. Firodia also invests in start-ups.

While Firodia’s daughter plays the piano and his son the guitar, they are captivated with the flying saucer-looking instrument their father is trying hard to master. **BT**

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OFF THE ROAD The Co-founders of Pepperfry go for at least two biking trips every year and prefer to ride with each other rather than a biking club

KNIGHT RIDERS

Ambrish Murty and Ashish Shah, Co-founders of Pepperfry, share a common love for biking

BY SMITA TRIPATHI

“WHEN WE STARTED working, we were bikers driven by need,” laughs Ambrish Murty (pictured, left), 50, who co-founded online furniture retailer Pepperfry along with Ashish Shah, 45, a decade ago. “But then for nearly two decades, we did not ride a bike. In a typical middle class way, we moved to cars,” adds Shah. But it was in 2018 that they rediscovered their love for biking. They hired bikes in Leh and rode to the Zaskar valley.

That trip was memorable. In 2020, immediately after the lockdown, Murty bought the Royal Enfield Himalayan and in October of that year rode it all the way from Mumbai to Ladakh. Shah joined him there and hired a bike and they rode around the area. On returning to Mumbai, Shah bought a Jawa 42.

Murty and Shah have three rules that determine their choice of bikes: 1) They should know how to fix it; 2) If they can’t fix it, anyone on the road should be able to fix it; 3) If no one can fix it, then it

should be cheap enough for it to be left in the middle of nowhere.

“Ladakh is a place that keeps calling you back,” says Shah. “We love off roading,” adds Murty. Besides Ladakh, they have done riding trips to Dhanushkodi in Tamil Nadu and also to Jodhpur, Jaisalmer and Udaipur in Rajasthan. Next on their list is the North-East, especially Sikkim and then Bhutan.

Murty and Shah love their bikes enough to name them. Murty’s is called Roasie, named after Rocinante, Don Quixote’s horse, while Shah’s is called Neo, after Neo in *The Matrix*.

They do at least two trips a year and prefer to ride with each other rather than some biking

club. On their trips they stop at Pepperfry studios, which are now present in nearly 90 cities. Pepperfry has expanded from 65 to 195 studios in the past 12 months. “We are also planning to open studios internationally,” says Murty. **BT**

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